blockade, as it would give the Soviets plenty of time to hide their missiles and protect them from an air attack. “Now as for the Berlin situation,” continued LeMay, addressing the president’s main concern and the source of his objection to the general strike option, “I do not share your view that if we knock off Cuba, they are going to knock off Berlin.” LeMay went on: “If we do not do anything to Cuba, then they’re going to push on Berlin and push *real hard* because they’ve got us on the run.”

LeMay was barely hiding his disdain for the young, inexperienced, and, in his opinion, indecisive president. “This is almost as bad as the appeasement at Munich,” said LeMay about the proposed blockade. This was more than disagreeing with the president: it was tantamount to a personal attack. The appeasement at Munich was closely linked in public perception with Joseph Kennedy’s tenure as US ambassador in London on the eve of World War II. LeMay did not stop there. “You are in a pretty bad fix,” he told the president. He argued that a blockade followed by negotiations would be perceived as showing weakness both at home and abroad. Kennedy had had enough. He interrupted the general: “What did you say?” LeMay repeated the phrase: “You are in a pretty bad fix.” “You are in there with me,” Kennedy shot back with a forced laugh. “Personally.”[15]

The meeting did not go well. If anything, it reinforced Kennedy’s distrust of the military. But their skepticism about a blockade was not lost on him, given his own doubts about it. Kennedy decided not to rush in making a final decision; he would stick to the original plan, and allow his advisers to continue their deliberations for another day or two. With most of them leaning toward a blockade, he asked Bundy to keep the strike alternative alive. He left Robert Kennedy in charge of the continuing discussions.[16]

When it came to Cuba, Robert Kennedy was nothing if not a hawk. Back in August he had been supportive of John McCone, who suggested that the Soviets might deploy nuclear missiles in Cuba. After the missiles were discovered on October 14, Robert pushed for an invasion when even General Taylor had his reservations about it. President Kennedy’s tapes caught his brother calling for an invasion whether that might cause a nuclear war or not and proposing to sink an American ship or stage an